10 QUESTIONS FOR THE BREEDER



Before you say yes to a puppy.

A good breeder loves these questions. A bad one hates them. Print them, take them along, tick as you go.

01 THE PARENTS

- [ ] **1 Can I meet the mom?**
  At the breeder's home, with her puppies. "Not here today" is a red flag.

- [ ] **2 Are both parents health tested?**
  Official X-rays of hips (HD, graded A–E), elbows (ED, 0–3) and shoulders (OCD), graded by the club's specialist, ideally eyes too. Ask to see the papers. Mine: hips A, elbows 0, shoulders clear.

- [ ] **3 Why these two, and what will the litter's COI be?**
  COI = inbreeding coefficient over 5 generations. Under 6.25% (like cousins); for a Swissy ideally under 2%, as in Swedish breeding. 12.5% (half-siblings) or more: no. More generations give a higher number.

- [ ] **4 How long did the grandparents live, and what were they sick with?**
  Some problems, such as epilepsy (often starting at 2–3 years), don't show on any X-ray.

02 THE PUPPY

- [ ] **5 Is the litter registered with the breed club?**
  A pedigree comes from the official studbook (FCI); kennel names can be checked in the FCI directory. In Slovakia, anyone selling puppies must be registered with the regional veterinary office (RVPS).

- [ ] **6 How old will the puppy be when it goes home?**
  My club: at least 7 weeks. Cornell vets: 8–12 weeks. Those weeks with mom and siblings teach bite control and dog manners.

- [ ] **7 What's already done?**
  Microchip entered in the national pet register, first vaccination, at least 2 dewormings. Rabies (from 12 weeks) and boosters come later with your vet.

- [ ] **8 How were the puppies raised?**
  The first 3 months matter most: visitors, noises, car rides, a busy home. Not a back room.

03 AFTER YOU SAY YES

- [ ] **9 Is there a written contract?**
  Price, health, pedigree, and a promise to take the dog back at any age.

- [ ] **10 Can I call you later?**
  Good breeders answer for years.

THE TWIST

A good breeder will question you too: your home, your time, your plans. If nobody asks you anything, that's your answer.

RED FLAGS

- × Puppies always available
- × Many breeds at once
- × Handover at a gas station
- × A deposit before you've visited

TEN QUESTIONS. A FEW AWKWARD MINUTES. TEN YEARS TOGETHER.

Sources: ŠVPS SR (buying a puppy, microchip and registration), Slovak Swiss Mountain Dog club breeding rules, Royal Kennel Club, Swedish and Norwegian Kennel Clubs (SKK, NKK), AKC, FOUR PAWS, Cornell Riney Canine Health Center, AVSAB, WSAVA, FCI, Frontiers in Veterinary Science 2022.

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